The cities of Lahore and Multan serve as plausible examples of the Ghazna Shansabanis' practices of re-inscription, as they entered the western corridors of the Indic sphere. Sultan Mahmud Ghaznavi had annexed Lahore probably quite early in his reign, near the beginning of his regular campaigns into the north Indian *duab*. The poet Fakhr-i Mudabbir (d. 1228; cf. Chapter 1), patronized by Iltutmish (r. AH 606–633/1210–1236 CE) at Delhi and writing during the early thirteenth century, made mention of Mahmud's commemoration of an Indian victory in AH 411/1019–1020 CE with the construction of a towering *minar* at Lahore.[12] Like its later parallels at Ghazna and Jam-Firuzkuh, the Lahore *minar* was probably associated with a nearby, contemporaneous mosque, possibly even the one identified in the lower *strata* of excavations within Lahore Fort.[13] Given the city's immense importance as the point of entry into and retreat from the north Indian plains, it was directly administered by deputies with military and legal authority, specially appointed by the Ghaznavid court throughout the reigns of Mahmud and Mas'ud I.[14] And we have already seen that Lahore was the refuge of the last two Ghaznavid rulers after the Shansabanis wrested Ghazna in AH 569/1173–1174 CE. Thus, this city was certainly well marked with an imperial Ghaznavid presence, and its continued strategic importance would make it equally valuable for Mu'izz al-Din's ambitions. Despite the absence of identifiable Shansabani-patronized architectural traces, the city could nonetheless have been appropriated and re-inscribed with Shansabani presence, for example, by means of continuing endowments to already existing mosques, *madrasa*s, and other "civic" institutions.

This was precisely the Shansabani method of appropriating the long prosperous city of Multan, at the nodal crossroads linking Panjab with Sindh and Zamindawar, and destinations beyond in virtually all directions. Since at least the seventh century and probably earlier, this city had also been renowned for its temple to Aditya, a Brahmanical–Hindu solar deity, serving as an exemplar of the historical nexus intertwining commerce and pilgrimage.[15] In the late tenth century, Multan's Isma'ili *da'i* Halam ibn Shaiban finally destroyed the temple on the orders of the Fatimid *khalifa* al-Mu'izz li-Din Allah (r. AH 341–364/952–975 CE) and replaced it with a mosque. This new foundation was apparently in close proximity to another mosque, probably the *masjid-i jami'* founded upon Muhammad ibn Qasim's conquest of the city *c.* AH 95/714 CE (with later renovations and enlargements, of course).[16] The Shi'a-affiliated Isma'ili presence in Sindh, whose missionary activity in the region had begun perhaps half a century before,[17] had cultivated strong trading networks between the Mediterranean and the western coasts of the subcontinent *via* the Indus, far beyond the regional overland routes that had converged on the Aditya Temple. It was surely the profitable Isma'ili-directed commerce that prevented Mahmud from definitively eradicating them on his campaign there in AH 395/1005–1006 CE, despite their heretical status